Mandarin Grammar Refresher

Recovering conversational grammar

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First draft ·Returning conversational speaker ·Simplified characters

How to use this refresher

For you if: you once spoke Mandarin conversationally, recognize much of the vocabulary, and now lose the thread of sentences or struggle to assemble your own. Explanations assume a native English speaker's likely habits.

Goal: recover a usable grammar toolkit: find a sentence's backbone, attach its modifiers correctly, express time and results, and connect clauses without translating English word order.

This is modern conversational Mandarin with broadly mainland usage. It is not a vocabulary course, tone tutorial, exhaustive grammar, or exam syllabus. Traditional characters can be generated from this edition; that changes the script, not the regional variety. Examples use English translations rather than full pinyin so you can concentrate on structure.

Fast pass: read Sentence backbone, Time and aspect, and Complements; then do the parsing task. **Full pass:** work through the modules, say the examples aloud, and complete the two short application tasks. Revisit only the constructions that break down in use.

Notation: S = subject; V = verb; O = object. A *complement* follows a verb or adjective and supplies a result, direction, degree, or similar information. Square brackets show chunks for analysis; they are not Chinese punctuation. A pattern is a useful default unless stated otherwise.

Diagnostic: five minutes

Try these before reading. Check the Answer key afterward.

1. Parse **我昨天在地铁上看的那篇文章很有意思。** What is the main claim? Which words belong inside the noun phrase? (Noun phrases)
2. Explain the difference between **我没去** and **我不去了**. (Questions and negation; Time and aspect)
3. Explain the difference between **我看了那份报告**, **我看完了那份报告**, and **我看不懂那份报告**. (Time and aspect; Complements)
4. Say "Please send me the address" using 把. (Moving the object)
5. Compare **他们不都去** and **他们都不去**. (Questions and negation)

If the words are familiar but these structures are hard, the core route is right for you. If unfamiliar vocabulary dominates, keep a dictionary nearby and substitute familiar nouns rather than stopping to memorize every example word.

Sentence backbone

Put the setting before the action

Default: S + time + place / other circumstances + V + O. Time can also precede S. Chinese verbs do not change form to mark English-style tense or agreement.

- **我明天在家工作。** I'll work at home tomorrow.
- **昨天她跟同事一起吃饭。** Yesterday she ate with her colleagues.

Pitfall: English often adds the setting afterward: "work at home." In the ordinary Chinese setting pattern, use **在家工作**. A location after the verb can instead describe the endpoint or resulting location: **放在桌上**, put it on

the table. Position changes the relationship; it is not arbitrary.

Do not force every possible adverb into one rigid slot chart. Start with who, when, where/with whom, then what happened. Add more structure only when the message needs it.

Topics are what the sentence is about

Pattern: topic + comment. The topic may be an object, a setting, or a larger category; the comment can have its own subject. Context also allows omitted subjects and objects.

- **这家餐厅，我以前来过。** This restaurant, I've been here before.
- **这件事，我还没告诉她。** As for this matter, I haven't told her yet.

Pitfall: the first noun is not necessarily the person doing the action. In the second example, 这件事 is what is being discussed; 我 is the subject of 告诉. Recover omitted material from context rather than inventing a new English-style subject for every clause.

Identity, description, and existence use different tools

Patterns: A + 是 + noun phrase; S + degree word + adjective; place + 有 + thing; known thing + 在 + place.

- **她是工程师，但最近很忙。** She's an engineer, but she's busy lately.
- **楼下有一家咖啡店。那家店在银行旁边。** There's a café downstairs. That café is next to the bank.

Pitfall: do not insert 是 just because English uses "is." **她很忙** describes her; **她是老师** identifies her. Unstressed 很 often makes a neutral adjective predicate sound natural; it need not mean an emphatic "very." Bare adjectives can occur in contrasts and other contexts: **这个贵，那个便宜。** This one is expensive; that one is cheap.

For negation: **不是** is not; **不忙** not busy; **没有** there isn't / don't have; **不在** isn't at the location.

Noun phrases

Put descriptions before the noun with 的

Pattern: modifier + 的 + noun. The modifier can be an owner, a description, or a whole clause. Chinese puts a relative clause before the noun it identifies.

- **我昨天买的手机已经坏了。** The phone I bought yesterday has already broken.
- **坐在窗边的那个人是我同事。** The person sitting by the window is my colleague.

Pitfall: English makes you expect "the person who …"; Chinese makes you wait for 人. In **[坐在窗边的] 那个人**, the whole bracket describes the person. Find the noun after 的 before deciding what the main sentence says.

的 is often omitted in close relationships (**我妈妈**, my mother) and established compact descriptions (**中文书**, Chinese-language book). With a longer identifying clause, keeping 的 is the safe default. If the noun is understood, it can disappear: **红的** means the red one(s).

Quantities need classifiers

Patterns: number + classifier + noun; 这/那 + classifier + noun. Classifiers categorize what is being counted; 个 is common but not universal.

- **我想买两张票。** I'd like to buy two tickets.
- **这本书比那本便宜。** This book is cheaper than that one. (The second 书 is understood.)

Pitfall: use 两 before most classifiers for "two": **两个人**, two people. 二 is used in counting, ordinal numbers, and numbers such as 十二. **第二次** means the second time; **两次** means twice. Useful familiar classifiers include 本 for books, 张 for tickets or flat items, 件 for matters or pieces of clothing, and 次 for occurrences.

Keep 的, 地, and 得 separate

They are usually pronounced neutral **de** in these grammatical uses, but they attach different things.

Form	Job	Example
Description + 的 + noun	Identify or describe a thing	**清楚的解释**: a clear explanation
Manner + 地 + verb	Describe how an action is performed	**耐心地解释**: explain patiently
Verb + 得 + description	Evaluate or describe an action	**解释得很清楚**: explain very clearly

- **她认真地检查了合同。** She carefully checked the contract.
- **她解释得很清楚，我听懂了。** She explained clearly, and I understood.

Pitfall: 得 is not a general substitute for 的. It follows the verb or adjective being expanded, not its object. See Complements for **中文说得很好** and for the separate potential use in **听得懂**. 地 is often omitted in simple spoken manner phrases; its absence is not automatically an error.

Questions and negation

Ask without moving the question word

Patterns: statement + 吗; V-not-V; question word in the position of the missing answer. Use 还是 for alternatives in a question and 或者 for alternatives in a statement.

- **你把钥匙放在哪儿了?** Where did you put the keys? Compare the answer: **我把钥匙放在桌上了。** I put them on the table.
- **你想今天去还是明天去?** Would you like to go today or tomorrow? **今天或者明天都可以。** Either today or tomorrow works.

Pitfall: do not front-load 什么 or 谁 by copying English question order. A neutral information question such as **你想吃什么?** (What do you want to eat?) does not add 吗. Likewise, choose **你去不去?** or **你去吗?** , rather than combining both neutral question formats.

为什么 asks why; **怎么** asks how, and can also express surprise or ask why: **你怎么没来?** How come you didn't come? **呢** can return the question to another topic: **我明天去。你呢?** I'm going tomorrow. What about you?

不 and 没 deny different things

Default: 不 denies a habit, state, intention, or prediction; 没 (有) denies occurrence or realization up to a reference time. 没有 is also the negative of 有.

- **我平时不喝咖啡，但昨天喝了。** I don't usually drink coffee, but I did yesterday.
- **我今天还没喝咖啡。** I haven't had coffee yet today.

Pitfall: these are not simply present versus past negatives. **他昨天不想出门。** He didn't want to go out yesterday. The desire is negated with 不 despite the past time. For an event that did not happen, say **没买**, not 没买了 with completed-event 了. Other sentence-final uses of 了 are a separate issue.

Use **别 + V** for "don't": **别着急。** Don't worry / don't rush. **别忘了带钥匙。** Don't forget to bring the keys. This fixed reminder also shows why "a negative can never appear with 了 " would be a bad rule.

Scope: what exactly does the negative cover?

Contrasts: 不都 = not all; 都不 = all not / none. 不一定 = not necessarily; 一定不 = definitely not.

- **他们不都住在北京。** Not all of them live in Beijing. **他们都不住在北京。** None of them live in Beijing.
- **他不一定来。** He may or may not come. **他一定不来。** He definitely won't come.

Pitfall: recognizing every word is insufficient if you flatten their order. Read adverbs as operators over the phrase that follows. In **我也不去** (I'm not going either), 也 adds another person to a negative claim; **我不再去** (I won't go anymore) negates further repetition.

Question words can lose their question meaning in a construction such as **谁都知道。** Everyone knows. **我什么都没买。** I didn't buy anything. With negation and 都, do not translate 什么 mechanically as a question.

Time and aspect

Time expressions say **when**. Aspect presents an event as realized, experienced, ongoing, or a maintained state. Chinese does not require every clause to carry an aspect particle. Context often supplies the time.

Verb 了: present an event as realized

Pattern: V + 了 + O, often with a quantity or other specification of the object. Perfective 了 views the event as a bounded occurrence; it does not by itself mean the entire task reached its intended endpoint.

- **我昨天看了三页。** I read three pages yesterday.
- **明天吃了早饭再出门。** Tomorrow, go out after having breakfast.

Pitfall: 了 is not an English past-tense ending. The second example places the event in the future. And **我看了那本书，但是没看完。** I read that book, but didn't finish it. To state completion of the whole reading task, use 完.

For a neutral denial of the event: **我没看那本书。** I didn't read that book. For a question: **你看了没有?** Did you read it? Bare **我买了书** can sound like part of a longer account; a specified object or further context often makes the message more complete.

Sentence-final 了: update the situation

Pattern: clause + 了. It signals a changed situation or a newly relevant state. At the end of a short sentence, the event and situation-update readings can overlap; not every 了 can be classified by position alone.

- **现在不下雨了。** It's not raining anymore.
- **我不去了。** I'm not going after all / anymore.

Pitfall: compare **我没去** (I didn't go) with **我不去了** (I've changed my plan / won't go now). The latter is an update about the situation, not a completed negative action.

我饿了。 I'm hungry now. No completed action needs to be imagined. **快下雨了。** It's going to rain soon. Again, nothing has happened yet.

过: experience, rather than an event report

Pattern: V + 过 + O; negative 没 (有) + V + 过 + O. 过 presents an experience before the relevant reference time, often at least once.

- **我去过成都，但没去过重庆。** I've been to Chengdu, but not Chongqing.
- **这道菜我以前吃过。** I've had this dish before.

Pitfall: 昨天我去了成都 reports a particular trip yesterday; **我去过成都** foregrounds having that experience. English "have" does not automatically call for 过: "I've lost my keys" would ordinarily be **我的钥匙丢了**, an event/current problem, rather than a claim about prior experience.

在 and 着: ongoing action versus maintained state

Patterns: 在/正在 + V for action in progress; V + 着 for a maintained state or accompanying action. 着 is **zhe** here, not the **zháo** in 睡着 (fall asleep).

- **她正在开门。门开着呢。** She's opening the door. The door is open.
- **他戴着耳机工作。** He's working with headphones on.

Pitfall: 开着 describes the open state in this context, not the motion of opening. Do not add 在 to every English "-ing": adjective states and activities that Chinese presents differently need their own constructions. **我知道** means "I know"; it is not normally 正在知道.

我在看书呢。 I'm reading. 呢 can support an ongoing-scene reading, but it has other conversational uses too; it is not a universal progressive ending.

Duration, frequency, and "still continuing"

Defaults: time-when before the action; duration generally after the verb; occurrence counts use 次. With an object, a repeated verb is often a clear way to attach duration.

- **我昨天看书看了两个小时。** I read for two hours yesterday.
- **我学中文学了三年了。** I've been studying Chinese for three years now.

Pitfall: distinguish **三年前** (three years ago), **三年** (for three years), and **三次** (three times). In the second example, final 了 helps present the accumulated duration as continuing to now. Compare **我以前学过三年中文。** I previously studied Chinese for three years. Do not mechanically apply English present-perfect forms.

等了十分钟 means waited ten minutes; **十分钟以后再来** means come again after ten minutes. If duration placement becomes awkward, simplify the sentence before adding objects and extra modifiers.

Complements

Treat the verb and what follows it as a package. This is often the missing step when all the individual words are familiar but the sentence remains hard to parse.

Result: what did the action achieve?

Pattern: V + result, optionally followed by 了 and an object. Common results: 完 finished, 懂 understood, 到 reached/obtained, 见 perceived, 好 ready/satisfactorily done, 错 wrong.

- **我听见了，但没听懂。** I heard it, but didn't understand.
- **我把地址写错了。** I wrote the address incorrectly.

Pitfall: 听 means listen; **听见** means hear; **听懂** means understand what one hears. An action and a successful result are different claims. **找了很久，还是没找到。** I looked for a long time and still didn't find it.

完 gives an endpoint, whereas 好 often suggests readiness or satisfactory completion: **饭做好了。** The meal is ready. A result complement does not itself locate the event in the past: **看完再告诉我。** Tell me after you finish reading.

Potential: can the result be achieved?

Pattern: V + 得 / 不 + result or directional complement. This often describes practical possibility under the circumstances. The negative is inside the package.

- **你说慢一点儿，我就听得懂。** If you speak a little more slowly, I can understand.
- **这个箱子太大，放不进去。** This box is too big; it won't fit inside.

Pitfall: 没听懂 says understanding did not happen; **听不懂** says the speech is beyond what the listener can understand in that context. **不能听** instead says listening is not possible or not allowed, depending on context. It does not specifically identify failure to understand.

今天做不完。 It can't all be finished today. Compare **今天不做完**: not finishing it today, for example as a choice in a suitable context. Moving 不 changes what is denied.

Degree and manner: how well, how far, with what effect?

Pattern: V + 得 + description; adjective + 得 + consequence. If the verb has an object, move the object earlier or repeat the verb.

- **她中文说得很流利。** She speaks Chinese fluently. Also: **她说中文说得很流利。**
- **我累得不想说话。** I'm so tired I don't want to talk.

Pitfall: don't leave the object between the verb and 得: for "speaks Chinese well," use **中文说得很好** or **说中文说得很好**. To deny the quality, say **说得不好**, not 不说得好. **不说** would deny speaking.

The 得 in **听得懂** marks potential, while **说得很清楚** evaluates clarity. Some short forms, such as **做得好**, can depend on context. Longer descriptive phrases and the corresponding negative often reveal the construction: **做得不好** evaluates quality; **做不好** can express inability to achieve a good result.

Direction: movement relative to a viewpoint

Pattern: V + direction + 来/去. 来 moves toward the contextual viewpoint; 去 moves away. Frequent combinations include 进来/进去, 出来/出去, 回来/回去, 上来/上去, 下来/下去.

- **外面太冷了，快进来。** It's too cold outside; come in.
- **请把这把椅子搬出去。** Please move this chair out.

Pitfall: "in" alone does not choose 来 versus 去; viewpoint matters. With a place object, the place normally comes before the final 来/去: **走进教室来**, walk into the classroom toward the viewpoint. Object placement with these complements has several patterns; the 把 construction is often a practical way to avoid a crowded verb phrase.

Direction also extends beyond physical movement: **想起来了** means remembered; **继续说下去** means keep speaking. Learn these as meaning-bearing chunks rather than translating each character literally.

Moving the object

把: foreground what happens to a particular thing

Pattern: S + (negation / modal) + 把 + identifiable O + V + result / destination / other elaboration. Use it to track an affected object and what is done to it.

- **请把地址发给我。** Please send me the address.
- **我没把那份报告看完。** I didn't finish reading that report.

Pitfall: 把 is not a generic object marker for every transitive sentence. A safe production strategy is a known/specified object and a concrete outcome. **把门关上** (close the door) and **把书放在桌上** (put the book on the table) are useful packages. Verbs such as 喜欢 do not ordinarily describe this kind of handling: **我喜欢这本书。** I like this book.

Place the relevant negation or modal before 把: **别把手机忘在车里。** Don't leave your phone in the car. A bare verb after the object often feels incomplete; tell the listener what happens to it. This is a default, not a claim that result complements are the only possible continuation.

被: foreground the affected participant

Pattern: affected S + 被 + (agent) + V + result / elaboration. The agent may be omitted. Common in adverse events, but not limited to them.

- **我的自行车被人偷走了。** My bicycle was stolen.
- **这个问题已经被解决了。** This problem has already been solved.

Pitfall: do not turn every English passive into 被. Chinese can often leave an agent unexpressed without a passive marker: **票买好了。** The tickets have been bought / are all sorted. Use 被 when the affected participant and what happened to it deserve attention.

For a negative: **门没被锁上。** The door wasn't locked. Recognize conversational passives with 让 or 叫 too, but remember that those words also mean let/make and call. Context must decide.

Comparisons and modals

Compare along a stated dimension

Patterns: A + 比 + B + adjective; A + 没有 + B + adjective; A + 跟 + B + 一样 + adjective. Put an exact difference after the adjective.

- **这条路比那条近两公里。** This route is two kilometers shorter than that one.
- **今天没有昨天那么冷。** Today isn't as cold as yesterday. **这间房跟那间一样大。** This room is as big as that one.

Pitfall: use **比以前好得多** (much better than before), not 比以前很好 for the ordinary comparative. **不比** denies being more; **没有** states falling short: **他不比我高** says he isn't taller than me, allowing equal height; **他没有我高** says he isn't as tall as me.

越来越 + adjective expresses change over time: **天气越来越热。** The weather is getting hotter. **越 A 越 B** links two changing quantities: **越练越熟。** The more you practice, the more familiar it becomes.

会, 能, 可以, 想, 要: choose the relationship

Default meanings: 会 learned ability or prediction; 能 ability/possibility under circumstances; 可以 permission or acceptable possibility; 想 desire/intention; 要 want, intend, require, or an imminent development, depending on context.

- **我会开车，但今天太累，不能开。** I can drive, but I'm too tired to drive today.
- **这里可以停车吗？我想停十分钟。** Is parking allowed here? I'd like to park for ten minutes.

Pitfall: these overlap, but they are not interchangeable translations of "can" and "will." **他会来的。** He'll come (a confident prediction). **他要来了。** He's about to come. **我不会游泳。** I don't know how to swim. **我不能游泳。** I can't swim in the present circumstances / am not allowed to.

For "don't need to," use **不用** or **不必**: **你不用等我。** You don't need to wait for me. **不要等我** is an instruction not to wait, not a statement that waiting is unnecessary. **应该** means should: **你应该早点休息。** You should get some rest earlier.

Connectors and conversational framing

就 and 才: timing, thresholds, and expectations

Patterns: time / condition + 就 + action; time / condition + 才 + action. 就 often suggests promptness, sufficiency, or "then"; 才 often marks a late threshold or "only then." Their other uses depend on construction.

- **他七点就到了，我九点才到。** He arrived as early as seven; I didn't arrive until nine.
- **十分钟就够了。** Ten minutes is enough. **我才等了十分钟。** I've only waited ten minutes.

Pitfall: 才 does not always mean "late" or "a large amount." With a small quantity it can mean "only," as in the second example. Do not assign either character one English translation. Read the time, condition, or quantity it comments on.

一到家就给我打电话。 Call me as soon as you get home. Here 一...就...links an immediate sequence; it is not a count of one phone call.

又, 再, 还, 已经: orient the event

Defaults: 又 repeats an occurrence; 再 proposes or projects repetition / a later next step; 还 means still or additionally; 已经 means already.

- **他昨天又迟到了。明天别再迟到了。** He was late again yesterday. Don't be late again tomorrow.
- **我已经吃过了，但她还没吃。** I've already eaten, but she hasn't eaten yet.

Pitfall: 又 and 再 are not fixed past and future tense markers. **明天又是星期一。** Tomorrow it's Monday again. It presents a recurring situation even though it is future. Use construction and perspective, rather than an English tense rule.

先吃饭，再讨论。 Eat first, then discuss it. 再 here orders a next step. **还要一杯水。** I'd also like another glass of water. 还 is hái in these uses; huán means return/give back in a different lexical use.

Connect the logic of clauses

Useful pairs: 因为...所以...because/therefore; 虽然...但是...although/but; 如果/要是...就...if/then; 只要...就... provided/then; 只有...才...only if/only then.

- **虽然很忙，但是我还是想去。** Although I'm busy, I still want to go.
- **只要有时间，我就去。只有周末，我才有时间。** If I have time, I'll go. Only on weekends do I have time.

Pitfall: unlike standard English "although ...but ...," Chinese commonly allows both halves of these pairs. Either half can also be omitted when the relation is clear. Do not confuse **只要**, a sufficient condition in the intended situation, with **只有**, a necessary condition.

For ordinary sentences, connect nouns with 和/跟, and clauses with an appropriate connector or a pause: **我买了菜，然后回家做饭。** I bought groceries, then went home to cook. Do not use 和 as the default English "and" between full clauses. **一边做饭一边听播客。** Cook while listening to a podcast: two simultaneous activities.

是...的: focus on a detail

Pattern: S + 是 + focused time / place / manner / agent detail + V + 的. A major use highlights details of an event treated as established in the conversation. 是 is often omitted in affirmative speech.

- **我是去年搬来的。** It was last year that I moved here.
- **这张照片是我朋友拍的。** This photo was taken by my friend. (Focus on who took it.)

Pitfall: this construction is not a replacement for past tense. **我去年搬来了** reports the move; **我是去年搬来的** highlights when. Other 是...的 sentences can make emphatic assertions and need not be past events: **他是会来的。** He really will come. Use the detail-focus pattern first; do not force every occurrence into it.

Small forms that make speech usable

Patterns: V + 一下 or verb reduplication for a brief/limited action; 吧 for suggestions or softened directives; 呢 for a continuing topic or scene. These affect conversational stance as well as literal content.

- **你看一下这个地址，对不对?** Take a quick look at this address. Is it right?
- **我们先坐下聊聊吧。** Let's sit down and chat for a bit first.

Pitfall: particles do not automatically make every demand polite. Relationship, intonation, and wording still matter. **给我看看。** Let me have a look. This can be ordinary among friends, but a more considerate request to a stranger is **可以让我看一下吗?** Could you let me take a quick look?

Contextual pronunciation worth recognizing

No tone drills are needed here. Keep just these connections between spelling and function in mind:

- **不** is normally bù, but becomes bú before a fourth-tone syllable in connected speech: **不是** bú shì. **一** changes in many connected contexts: **一天** yì tiān; **一个** yí ge (个 is commonly neutral here, with an underlying fourth tone). Counting and ordinal uses often retain yī. Pinyin in dictionaries may show underlying tones.
- **了** is neutral le as the particle, but liǎo in forms such as **了解** liǎojiě (understand) and **受不了** shòu bu liǎo (can't stand it). **得** is neutral de in complements, děi in **我得走了** (I have to go), and dé in **得到** (obtain).

Pitfall: a familiar character does not guarantee the same grammatical role or reading. Third-tone changes and neutral-tone patterns still occur normally; they are outside this grammar review's teaching scope.

Apply it

Task 1: parse before translating

Spend five to ten minutes on this paragraph. Bracket the long noun phrase, identify the main predicates, and label the result, potential, and 把 constructions. Then give an idiomatic English translation.

我昨天在地铁上看的那篇文章，你看完了吗？我看了两遍，还是有几句看不懂。你要是有时间，就把最难的那一段给我解释一下吧。

Success means you can explain what the speaker read, what remains difficult, and what help they request. Merely replacing each word with English is not enough.

Task 2: recover a useful message

Write or say a six-to-eight-sentence message to a friend. You planned to meet tonight, worked longer than expected, have not finished a report, and propose meeting tomorrow instead. Include:

- A contrast between the original plan and the updated situation.
- An unachieved result, not just a negated action.
- A conditional proposal.
- A request to send you the address, and a statement about what to do on arrival.

Spend ten minutes, then compare with the model. Different wording is welcome. Check whether a listener could reconstruct your plan, the obstacle, and the requested next steps. If not, repair those relationships before polishing vocabulary.

Answer key

Diagnostic

1. **[我昨天在地铁上看的] 那篇文章 / 很有意思。** Main claim: that article is interesting. The bracket means “that I read on the subway yesterday”; it modifies 文章. 我 is the subject inside the modifier, not the subject of 很有意思. Translate: “The article I read on the subway yesterday is interesting.”
2. **我没去**: I didn’t go / haven’t gone. It denies the occurrence. **我不去了**: I’m not going after all / anymore. It updates the plan or situation.
3. **我看了那份报告**: I read that report; it does not by itself guarantee I finished it. **我看完了那份报告**: I finished reading it. **我看不懂那份报告**: I can’t understand the report. The final two use result and potential complements, respectively.
4. **请把地址发给我。**请 softens the request; 把 introduces the identifiable address; 发给我 states the transfer to me.
5. **他们不都去**: not all of them are going. **他们都不去**: none of them are going. In this context, 不 before 都 denies the universal claim; 都 before 不 distributes the negative across everyone.

Task 1 model

[我昨天在地铁上看的] 那篇文章，你看完了吗？ The bracket modifies 文章, and the entire article phrase is the topic. Main clause: 你看完了吗? **看完** is read + finish.

我看了两遍，还是有几句看不懂。 The speaker read it twice; 遍 counts complete passes through material. **看不懂** is inability to understand; **有几句** introduces the few sentences that remain problematic. Reading through something and understanding it are separate outcomes.

你要是有时间，就把最难的那一段给我解释一下吧。要是...就...gives a condition and requested response. 把 marks the particular paragraph to be explained. **给我** identifies the person receiving the explanation. 一下 limits the request, and 吧 softens it.

“Have you finished the article I was reading on the subway yesterday? I’ve read it twice, but there are still a few sentences I can’t understand. If you have time, could you explain the hardest paragraph to me?”

Task 2 model

我们本来约好今晚见面。可是我今天加班，九点才下班。报告还没写完。我今晚去不了了。要是你明天有时间，我们就明天见吧。请把地址发给我。我到了以后就给你打电话。

“We originally agreed to meet tonight. But I worked overtime today and didn’t get off work until nine. The report still isn’t finished. I can’t make it tonight after all. If you have time tomorrow, let’s meet tomorrow. Please send me the address. I’ll call you once I arrive.”

Notice **才** marking a late time, **没写完** denying an achieved result, **去不了** describing inability to go, and final **了** updating the situation. **到了以后** establishes arrival as the condition for the later call; it does not make the call a past event.

Quick reference

A parsing routine

1. Find the main predicate. Does it say identity (是), description (adjective), existence (有), location (在), or an action?
2. Bracket each long **...的 + noun** group. Find where the modifier ends before interpreting the main clause.
3. Recover the topic, subject, and omitted objects from context.
4. Read the full verb package: action + result/direction; potential 得/不; descriptive 得; aspect particles.
5. Check negation and adverb scope. Then connect clauses by time, condition, contrast, or cause.

Choose the construction by the message

What you want to say	Useful pattern
An event happened	V + 了; time comes from context
A situation has changed	Clause + 了
Something did not happen	没 (有) + V
Something is no longer the case	不 + predicate + 了
You have prior experience	V + 过
An action is in progress	在/正在 + V
A state is maintained	V + 着
An action achieved a result	V + result
A result cannot be achieved	V + 不 + result
You describe performance	V + 得 + description
A known object is handled	把 + O + V + elaboration
A participant is affected	Affected S + 被 + (agent) + V...
You identify a thing	Modifier + 的 + noun
You highlight an event detail	是 + detail + V + 的

Recover by producing contrasts

After reading, make one personal sentence for each pair: 不/没; 了/过; 在/着; 没听懂/听不懂; 不都/都不; 就/才; 只要/只有. If the meaning changes as intended, move on. If not, return to that unit and say the examples in a new context.

Sources and further review

This is an original teaching draft with original examples, not an adaptation of one textbook. The following teaching references were consulted to check selected distinctions and provide a route to fuller explanations. Language instruction benefits from a teacher's judgment about context and naturalness; this draft has not yet received that review.

- University of Oxford, Centre for Teaching Chinese as a Foreign Language, grammar database index. Further explanations of aspect, complements, word order, and related constructions.
- Oxford CTCFL, the 得 construction: descriptive complements and placement of verb objects; the 把 construction: affected objects and elaborated verb phrases; comparatives: 比, 没有, and 一样.
- Cheng & Tsui, *Integrated Chinese*, third edition, Level 1 Part 1, publisher's lesson sample, grammar discussion of 了: why it is not a past-tense marker, including future event sequences.
- OpenCC project: the tool used for the optional traditional-character edition. Automated script conversion does not establish regional usage or linguistic review.

References checked 2026-11-09. Editorial next step: a Mandarin instructor or proficient native speaker should review example naturalness, the 了 contrasts, complement interpretations, and traditional conversion before the course is marked reviewed.